

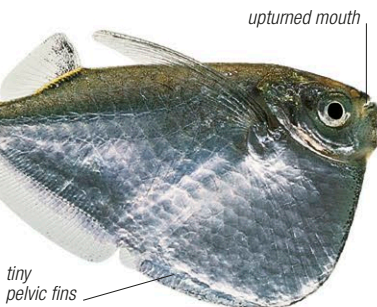
Gasteropelecus sternicla

River hatchetfish



Length 2½ in (6.5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location N. to C. South America



The river hatchetfish gets its name from its narrow shape, and deep, blade-like keel. The most unusual feature of this silver-gray fish is its highly enlarged pectoral fins. When threatened, or when chasing prey, the river hatchetfish uses these fins to gain speed in the water and even to take off into the air. Marine hatchetfishes belong to a different group of fishes, and have a different lifestyle.

Gymnotus carapo

Banded knifefish

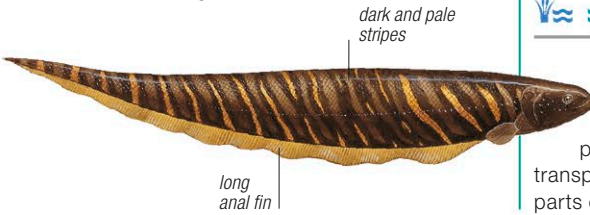


Length 23½ in (60 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location Central America to C. South America



A close relative of the electric eel (see above right), this freshwater fish has a similar cylindrical body tapering toward its finless, rod-shaped tail. The banded knifefish is a bottom-dwelling species that inhabits murky, still water. It produces weak electric currents with which it senses its environment. Produced by specially adapted muscle tissue close to the tail, the electric currents are also used to communicate with one another and for males to attract mates. It moves by rippling the long fin on its underside, but it is not a strong swimmer.



Hoplias macrophthalmus

Giant trahira



Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight Up to 4½ lb (2 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location Trinidad, Central America to C. South America



The giant trahira has a thick, stocky body with a blunt snout, very large eyes, and a somewhat rounded stomach. It has 2 or 3 canines in its upper jaw, in addition to a series of conical teeth. This fish can tolerate low oxygen conditions and has been known to move across land at night between bodies of water. An important food fish, it is raised in aquaculture.

Silurus glanis

Wels catfish

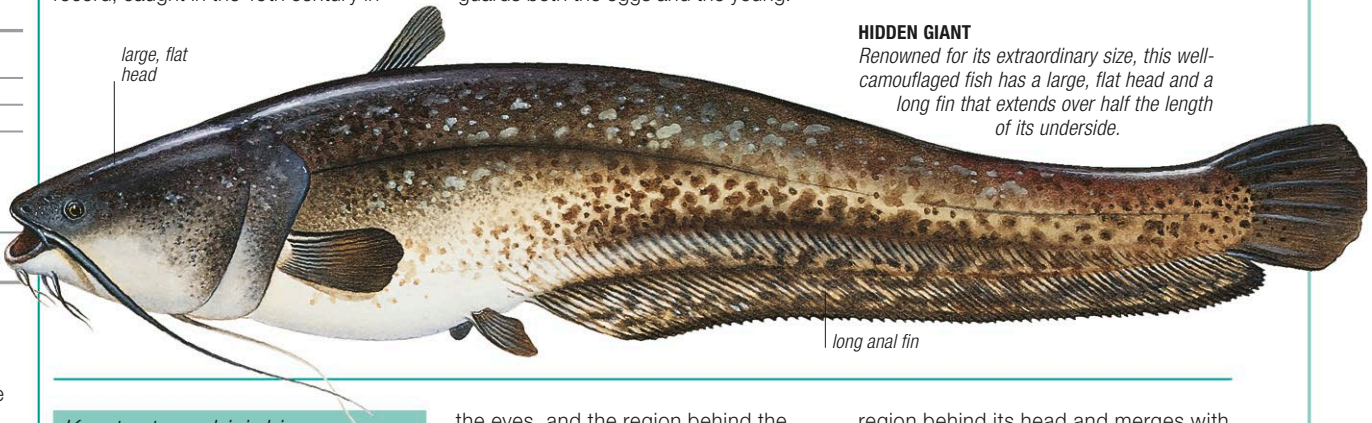


Length Up to 16 ft (5 m)
Weight Up to 660 lb (300 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location C. Europe to C. Asia



This huge, bottom-dwelling catfish is one of the largest freshwater fishes in the world. The biggest specimen on record, caught in the 19th century in



Kryptopterus bicirrhis

Glass catfish



Length 6 in (15 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



Many catfishes are camouflaged by their dark markings, but this slender species is protected by being almost transparent. The only clearly visible parts of its body are the backbone,

Electrophorus electricus

Electric eel

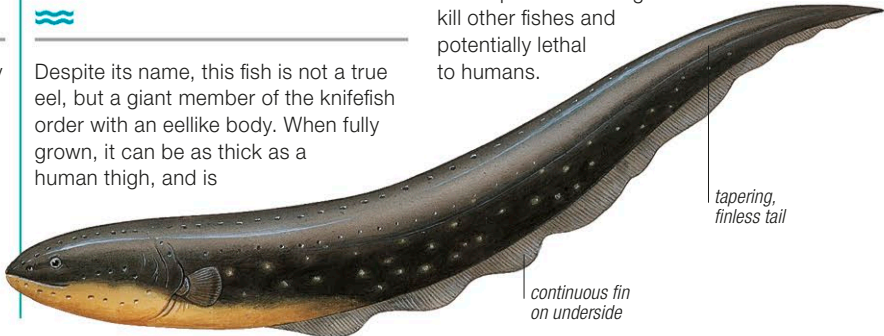


Length Up to 8¼ ft (2.5 m)
Weight Up to 44 lb (20 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location N. South America

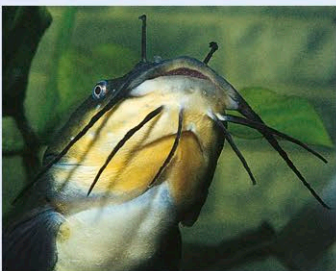


Despite its name, this fish is not a true eel, but a giant member of the knifefish order with an eellike body. When fully grown, it can be as thick as a human thigh, and is



one of the largest freshwater fishes in South America. It has a continuous fin that runs along its underside, but no fins on its back; its tail tapers to a sharp, finless point. Electric eels have poor eyesight, and find their way by using weak pulses of electricity. However, using modified muscles, or electric organs, that run the entire length of their bodies, they can also produce sudden jolts of up to 600 volts—powerful enough to kill other fishes and potentially lethal to humans.

FOOD SENSORS



The wels catfish has 2 very long barbels attached to its upper jaw, and 4 smaller ones below its mouth, which help it find food.

HIDDEN GIANT

Renowned for its extraordinary size, this well-camouflaged fish has a large, flat head and a long fin that extends over half the length of its underside.

the eyes, and the region behind the head that contains its digestive and reproductive organs. Its transparency is the result of thin skin, and of body tissues that are suffused by oils, which make its flesh translucent. The glass catfish's body is flattened from side to side, and its dorsal fin is reduced to one or 2 rays, or is missing altogether. As in many other catfishes, it has a very long anal fin, which stretches from the

region behind its head and merges with the base of its tail. This fish inhabits lowland flood plains and large rivers with turbid waters. Individuals gather in small groups at an oblique angle to the water surface. Several other groups of fishes contain species that have transparent or nearly transparent bodies. For example, the Indian glassfish, which actually comes from Southeast Asia, is often kept in aquariums.

